

Church Discipline on Pornography: An Examination of the Criteria for Harmful Sin vs. Harmless Sin

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Introduction

This paper will examine pornography in the church, and the method for determining whether a the sin is harmful or harmless. The findings include that pornography is intrinsically categorized as sin because it is lust with the eyes and is a sexual sin, and psychological studies show that this is the case.

But not all sin must be disciplined. There are cases when the Christian is repentant but cannot stop watching porn because he is addicted because it is a drug. Therefore, we must gently restore the person.

Education from the beginning of conversion is the solution to the problem.

Is Pornography harmful or harmless? We find monkeys and children exploring their own bodies and touching themselves. Is that bad?

In my mind, there is a fine line between harmful and harmless. I believe it is healthy to explore one's body because we are made to be sexual. Sex is a gift from God, and many Christians uphold this. But it is when it is perverted that it is bad - when there is misconduct.

Therefore, is pornography a sin? Should there be church discipline for it?

I would like to explore the harmfulness of porn on the person and on others. Also, by concluding that it is indeed harmful in some ways, the solutions we can adopt to fix this problem. A small discussion about the nature of this sin and the historicity of it throughout all the ages is discussed as well.

The essence of the paper is: porn is morally and practically harmful; religious commitment can intensify the shame-indulgence cycle; porn is not just harming self but harming others; church discipline must understand rather than be punitive as porn-users are victims most of the time; fear of church discipline prevents healing and the church has the capacity to heal; porn reduces intimacy; and initial training at the start of conversion is essential for all Christians.

The thesis is: porn is determined to be harmful to most people, and a loving church discipline must be adopted to restore a person without punishment because porn-users are victims most of the time, and Kantian education from the beginning of conversion is the best solution to prevent this from happening.

The first source¹ is a psychological study and survey of UK Christian men about their use of pornography and prostitution. For the purposes of this paper, we will focus on just pornography.

What's so interesting about this study is that the majority of the survey-takers are "Strong Christians" - "93%" (Lau and Miles 2023, 8). This allows us to see what very dedicated Christians would do - whether they will watch pornography or not. And the results of the survey is that 53% of Strong Christians had "out-of-control" sexual compulsions or behaviors (8).

In fact, it says, there is a "positive relationship between religiousness and pornography-viewing behaviour," which means that the more religious and Christian a person was, the more compelled they were to view pornography (4). This is an interesting point that I hope to get to later in the paper, where religiousness actually has a detrimental effect - causing a spiral of guilt and indulgence, guilt and indulgence.

One of the important points that the survey and paper talks about is the morality of pornography and prostitution. It says, "males paying for sex will give no thought to where the woman has come from or what circumstances have led her into prostitution" (3).

This highlights that regardless of whether pornography is harmful to the user, it is harmful to the people who created the video; and so, in effect, it harms others. Paul the Apostle said in the Bible that sexual sin is a sin against your own body, but it is clear from this citation that sexual sin harms others.

¹ Timothy C. Y. Lau and Glenn M. Miles, "'I Think It's Biblically Wrong, but Temptation Gets the Better of Me': A Survey on Out-of-Control Sexual Behavior in a Christian Cohort of Men in the UK," *Dignity: A Journal of Analysis of Exploitation and Violence* 8, no. 1 (2023): Article 7, <https://doi.org/10.23860/dignity.2023.08.01.07>

But what's interesting about the survey is that it does not just talk about the morality of pornography from a theoretical view, but it asks the surveyors to rate their view of the morality of porn.

“66% of young adult men in their sample reported concerns about their pornography-viewing behaviour being inconsistent with their religious beliefs” (5).

This shows that because they are Strong Christians, they know and believe that porn is going against God and the Bible. They are going against their own conscience when they watch porn.

“**62%** (304) of all participants thought it was morally wrong, with more than half (55%, 272) believing it was *abusive to actors* who were made in God's image. From a behavioural perspective, more than half (56%, 294) of participants thought watching pornography could lead to other forms of negative sexual behaviour. Additionally, 58% (286) believed it could lead to a *breakdown of relationships, including marriage*. About a third (34%, 165) of all participants thought watching pornography could make viewers feel physically inadequate” (11).

“**three-quarters** (74%, 361) of all participants **negatively perceived pornography**” (11).

And so we see that the surveyors viewed it not just a problem as a sin against God, but as a moral problem and a practical problem. They say it is “abusive to actors” and can damage marriages.

At this point, I want to talk about Church Discipline. One question we may ask is, “What is the purpose of Church Discipline?” Why would we be so cruel as to bring down the hammer on someone, rather than love them and build them up?

Church Discipline is a dangerous act, that can potentially harm someone. I know this for a fact for myself, because I was banned from a church. In fact, our video lecturer, Bill Mounce, admitted that he was banned from around four churches as a pastor because he preached in a way that resulted in friction with the churches.

So, we can ask the question, “Should we ban someone from the church because he or she watches porn?” And the criteria to evaluate this answer includes the dimension: “Does it harm the user or others (such as people in the video or the spouse of the user)?”

You see, essentially it is saying that the purpose of Church Discipline is not just to harm people and hammer down on people, but to promote social peace and harmony by rebuking evil deeds that harm people. The dimension I just talked about is harm to people, which is a utilitarian perspective. “If it harms people, we need to stop it,” one may say. And from the survey results of Strong Christians, we realize that it is harm to the user and to others. We need to apply church discipline to the usage of pornography. But to what degree?

You see, I want to admit something here. I am an addict of pornography. Some bullies in middle school told me to watch it and to masturbate to it, and once I did it, they said, “Do it again! How did you like it?” And soon, the chemicals on my brain was addicted to it, and I had to keep going to it everyday.

Am I a victim?

Actually, yes, I am.

It was actually because I was such a sincere Christian they wanted me stumble and they tempted me.

This is my own fault in some sense, but it is also my biggest sin in my life that I regret.

I hope that even though I deserve Church Discipline, that I can receive grace and forgiveness and mercy.

You see, I've tried to stop many times. After talking with Professor Jowers, I resolved to stop, but eventually I went back to my sin.

I am repentant, and I want to stop, I just can't because the chemicals in my brain and my body is addicted.

Am I a bad Christian?

No.

Do I need help rather than harsh judgment and rebuke?

Yes, I need help rather than rebuke because I already know it is harmful and wrong.

And so Church Discipline needs to be tailored to each person. If a person is blatantly damaging other people, we need to stop it immediately and fight harshness with harshness. But if it is a sincere Christian like me who wants to stop in the first place and wants help, we need to help the Christian and allow him to stay in the church.

Lau and Miles' paper says "When asked if they were afraid of facing church discipline for being honest about their sexual behaviour (out-of-control or otherwise), about 26% (125) of all respondents answered 'yes'" (18). This shows that we need grace for these people.

Almost everyone responded they have "shame, embarrassment, disapproval, and stigma...Some participants stated they were even asked to leave their church due to their sexual behaviour" (18).

The following section of this paper will examine Lau and Miles' survey of what the surveyors believed would help them, and the paper's recommendation for the church.

They said that the church can “promote growth through restorative support for those who face such behavioural challenges” (5).

“To determine **how the church could help address unwanted sexual behaviours** (out-of-control or otherwise), participants were given a list of reasons and the option to mark multiple choices. The top three choices were: **one-on-one, face-to-face accountability and support** (334, 68%), **marriage enrichment classes/weekends** (63%, 309), and **youth sex education** (60%, 297). The lowest response (43%, 213) was recorded for **online group accountability and support** (see Table 9)” (19)

“Over nine in ten men said they thought the **church could help men in sexual matters.**” (20)

“**Rebuild trust from within the Christian community by cultivating safe, meaningful spaces** of support and accountability for Christian men. This could include **small group settings or recovery groups**” (20).

As you can see, the men and women who have sexual problems understand that the church has the ability to help them.

I repeat, the church should not hammer down on these people because we don’t know their stories, and these “Strong Christians” want help themselves. We need to understand that the church should not demonize these people, but rather come along side them and help them. We need to love them.

The survey says, the church could “**provide more support** for those struggling with using pornography and compulsive behaviour. This could include **education, counseling, and other resources**” (21)

“Provide more education on the **harmful effects of pornography on individuals and society**. This could include highlighting the link between pornography, **sexual exploitation, and trafficking** and **promoting healthy sexual relationships** within **marriage**” (21)

The next source² also supports a loving approach to church discipline on porn. They say “need for effective loving guidance in their pastoral care.”

What is so interesting is that the paper says, “Some researchers doubt whether pornography and cybersex addiction really are addictions or whether they are just labels attached to persons because of religiously inspired shame and guilt.” What this is saying is that some people think that porn is not a problem and not a sin, and that it is just being religiously persecuted with a type of Pharisaic-ism. Whether this is true is besides the point, and I personally don’t know because this may be a biological issue.

But for those who want help, the paper suggests a “healing process that can lead to the liberation from pornography and cybersex addiction with the help of fellow-believers who become the embodiment of love, forgiveness and acceptance.”

“Pornography and cybersex addictions are common results when a person starts using a substitute in the place of healthy intimacy,” which is a sign that we need more real relationships in people’s lives, rather than just porn. I think this is actually true of myself, where I was totally isolated when I was a youth, and thus I resorted to porn. I definitely think that more human interaction would have been better for me.

“Looking at pornography is, in essence, a secretive act that distances the user from other people while satisfying the person's own desires, regardless of whether it is at the expense of the

² Gert Breed, “Fellow Believers Helping Persons Addicted to Pornography by Becoming an Embodiment of Love,” *In die Skriflig/In Luce Verbi* 56, no. 1 (2022): 1–9, <https://doi.org/10.4102/ids.v56i1.2834>

self and others,” which shows that it is most likely a sin because it is secretive, especially because it is at the expense of people.

“Even if the **religious convictions of the addicted person suggest the opposite**, he or she looks at other **humans as sexual objects. Sex and real intimacy are separated** in the brain of the addicted person. Pornography supplies **orgasm without real life intimacy**, and often escalates to a point where the addicted person is not capable of being aroused by the real body and presence of another human being (Hall 2014:73; Luscombe 2016:40). **Couples are then robbed of sexual intimacy** (Hall 2014:68). This leads to **broken families and a society that suffers from the stranglehold of pornography on addicted people.**”

This shows that real intimacy is lost when people just use porn. People are viewed as objects, orgasms are experienced without a spouse, and broken families and a broken society is what emerges.

The next paper³ talks about experiencing sexual attraction in professional settings, particularly ministry settings. It says that this topic has been “shrouded by silence, secrecy, and even cover-up.”

It says that “37% of pastors confessed to having been involved in inappropriate sexual behavior with someone in the church, and 12% had engaged in sexual intercourse with a church member.” That is truly a staggering number. That means that in every town, there is probably at least one pastor who has had sexual intercourse with a church member.

It seems that the cause of this misbehavior is “issues of power, institutional inattentiveness, clergy disillusionment, personal crisis, loneliness, unexpressed depression, church/marital conflict, and facing ambiguous boundaries.”

³ Katheryn Rhoads Meek, Mark R. McMinn, Todd Burnett, Chris Mazzearella, and Vitaliy Voytenko, “Sexual Ethics Training in Seminary: Preparing Students to Manage Feelings of Sexual Attraction,” *Journal of Psychology and Theology* 45, no. 2 (2017): 109–121.

It tells us that the Church needs to uphold “initial and ongoing education as well as effective regulation in order to protect the public and maintain the integrity of the institution.”

And this is the solution. We can discuss the causes and the problem in-depth, but what is the solution? The solution is to allow us to be educated and to stop it in its tracks.

When I took the counseling courses, premarital education, and leadership courses at Faith Seminary, I knew from the start that there would be sexual temptations and inappropriate feelings that would come when I start working or do ministry.

And I have found that a strict obedience to Christ is the only solution to this problem. A Kantian approach is the only approach.

Why?

Because when you are facing temptation, there is a lot of thoughts that justify the wrong behavior. “I feel this way, so I want to sin.” There is too much wrong thinking. In order to breakthrough all the wrong thinking and behavior and get to the pure gospel, we need Kantian thinking. Christianity is the only solution to this problem.

A clear separation between light and darkness is what is needed to overcome sexual temptation, and that can only be done as a strong Christian.

The next paper⁴ is on how the religious and sanctified are becoming porn-saturated. It says, Christians have been the “most ardent opponents to pornography’s dissemination and use historically, there is a growing—but thus far untested—assumption that they too are following this same trend.”

⁴ Samuel L. Perry and Andrew L. Whitehead, “Are the Sanctified Becoming the Pornified? Religious Conservatism, Commitment, and Pornography Use, 1984–2016,” *Journal for the Scientific Study of Religion* 58, no. 1 (2019): 162–183.

Christians have always said, “Pornography is wrong! Don’t watch it!” But these days, they are watching it.

The reason Christians don’t like it is because they view it as a “clear violation of biblical mandates to avoid nonmarital sexual desire or “lust,” encouraging solo-masturbation and fornication, at best, and at worst contributing to homosexuality, rape, venereal disease, and child molesting.”

And so I’d like to say that the world will always encroach upon the Christians in any age. During the times of Jesus, the Greek Christians, like the Corinthians, would engage in sex with prostitutes. Now that we have technology to view pornography on the Internet, we must fight this temptation and sin.

In conclusion, sex sells - and it has been sold to the Christians as well. We must fight back, and restore sex. Sex was given to us before the fall of Adam and Eve, and therefore, we must keep the marriage bed undefiled (Bible), yet active and pure. To do this, we need education right from the start.

The reason I fell into pornography as a kid, and as does so many people, is that I didn’t even know what pornography was. The world pulled me in and got me addicted. I didn’t know what I was doing. If I had education from a young age, I would have been saved and safe.

Sex has been a problem throughout the ages, even in the time of the Corinthians, and we must constantly fight sexual temptation daily.

We must understand our brothers who have fallen into this sin, and gently raise them up, without being harsh or punitive.

Love is the answer.

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